

Why is such an act practised? The most common reason is that providers concerned about the capacity limits of their network may implement a short-term cap so that they can accommodate more customers without having to scale up their service infrastructure.

Retired Squadron Leader Sanjay Sinvhal faces just such an artificial hurdle: “I acquired a Powersurfer broadband connection a few months back from BSES Telecom, Mumbai. The browsing and downloads were blazing fast for the first couple of months and then suddenly I hit a roadblock. The speeds offered became painfully slow. After a lot of follow-up and complaints, what came out is that the download/browsing speeds will be between 48 Kbps to 64 Kbps only.” This downgrading of speed formed what was officially termed as a ‘Manageable network’. As Rajiv Sharaf, head of Customer Support at Powersurfer explains in a e-mail to Sinvhal, the port speed was restricted to 48 Kbps “for fine tuning of network and better bandwidth management”. Sinvhal failed to see how this capped connection certified itself as broadband. “On a dial-up modem, I get connectivity at 56 Kbps. An ISDN connection provides 128 Kbps; a DSL connection provides 128 Kbps to 2 Mbps of speed; streaming video needs 786 Kbps minimum, streaming audio needs 64 Kbps minimum. A broadband consists of streaming audio, video and data. I thus fail to understand that if they have reduced the access speed to 48 Kbps, how can they sell the service as a broadband connection? Charging the subscribers for a broadband connection, without delivering is unethical, to say the least.”

Only in India

It is obvious that as far as home users are concerned, a broadband connection is the proverbial white elephant in India. Internet access speeds offered by the best service providers seldom exceed 40 Kbps, when they should be touching the 1 Mbps mark. The reasons are largely financial and to a lesser degree infrastructural. Leasing lines from ISPs is an expensive deal and few can afford to set up their own Internet gateways. Consider a service provider that rents a 2 Mbps line with the intent of providing Internet over Cable. The customers are promised blazing speeds, and initially everyone seems to be happy. Word of their excellent service spreads and new users are brought under the wing. What follows is a vicious cycle—to be profitable, the service provider will not refuse the users who wish to sign on. The increased user-base will overload the limited bandwidth and

SCOREBOARD



Question	a	b	c
1	15	10	5
2	10	5	15
3	5	10	15
4	15	10	5
5	5	15	10

25-40 Tsk, tsk. You got what techies term a 'lemon' for a broadband connection

40-60 Hmmm. The signs are good, but we wouldn't hedge bets on your Internet connection

60-75 Wow, an Internet access God! Can we be best friends?

pretty soon there will be many distraught customers. It is a scenario that is not too uncommon, one that forces us to accept what is essentially an always-on-dial-up-connection as a true broadband solution. Perhaps the best recourse is to grit our teeth and bear it. Who amongst us, after all, has won against the system?

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